

APARTHEID A policy of segregation and discrimination against the nonwhite population of South Africa. The term is from the Afrikaans for “separateness.”

As the 1970s and 1980s progressed, violence escalated, including violence between rival black factions such as the ANC and the Inkatha Freedom Party. All dissent was suppressed by a police force and military who habitually committed atrocities, including torture. In 1986 the international community imposed economic sanctions on South Africa in an attempt to force an end to apartheid but, even with the majority of whites now opposed to the system, the government still failed to respond with significant reform.

A new beginning

It took a new administration to open the way for change. President F.W. de Klerk was elected in 1989 and lifted bans on the ANC and other opposition groups. On February 11, 1990, Nelson Mandela was released. Mandela and de Klerk achieved the transition of South Africa to democratic majority rule under difficult circumstances. They faced different views from tribal and political factions within the black community and opposition to change from some whites. Their solution was

to adopt a unified approach, and in 1994 Nelson Mandela was elected president of South Africa, becoming head of the Government of National Unity in which minority parties, including vice-president de Klerk’s National Party, were represented.

The new government recognized that if unity was to be achieved between its divided communities, it must take action. The antiapartheid campaigner Archbishop Desmond Tutu was appointed head of the Truth and Reconciliation Commission (TRC), which was a historic attempt to address the violence and human rights abuses of the apartheid era. Over a three-year period the commission heard the testimonies of both the victims and the perpetrators of crimes. Although never intended as an instrument of punishment, the TRC



ANC logo

On the flag, black represents those who fought for freedom; green, the land reclaimed from oppressors; and gold, South Africa’s natural wealth. The shield and spear represent the early years of struggle, and the wheel is a symbol of unity.

bore witness to the suffering of victims and could grant perpetrators amnesty from possible prosecution. In 1998 the TRC published its findings. Atrocities committed by all sections of society were condemned, including the actions of the black vigilante group Mandela United Football Club, led by Nelson Mandela’s former wife, Winnie.

The extraordinary ambition of the TRC was to heal the wounds of a brutal past by acknowledging their truth. South African willingness to engage in this process won the nation worldwide respect. In his response to the commission’s findings, Nelson Mandela called on people to “celebrate and strengthen what we have done as a nation as we leave our terrible past behind us forever.”

Act of defiance

Archbishop Desmond Tutu addresses a gathering of the Defiance Campaign against Unjust Laws in Cape Town, in 1988. Many “defiers” were imprisoned for peaceful protest.

The apartheid system has disappeared, but its effects are still felt in South Africa.

LEGACIES IN SOUTH AFRICA

The majority of the poor are black and the bulk of property remains in white ownership. The government, led since 1999 by **Thabo Mbeki**, has introduced various measures to create greater equality.



THABO MBEKI

ROLE IN AFRICA

South Africa’s foreign policy now aims to **promote the economic, political, and cultural regeneration of Africa**, through the New Partnership for African Development (NEPAD). South Africa has also played an active role in seeking an end to crises in Burundi and the Democratic Republic of Congo.

AIDS

One of the major challenges facing South Africa is an **HIV/AIDS epidemic 464–65**, which is decimating the economically active population.

AIDS AWARENESS RIBBON



Freedom day

On April 27, 1994, millions of South Africans lined up to exercise their newly won right to vote in the first free election held after apartheid. A government of National Unity was elected.

